Evidence suggests, however, that this was the period when Gandhi gave the formal approval for the final stage of work toward a peaceful nuclear explosion.[297] In July 1972, Gandhi stressed that India's policy was "to investigate the possibility of peaceful nuclear explosions, but not to develop nuclear weapons."[298] There is some debate about when the decision for a peaceful nuclear explosion in principle was made. Whatever the exact date, most of the available evidence suggests that a decision in principle was made in late summer or fall 1971. This indicates a time after it had become clear that India could no longer hope for US protection and might have to look entirely to Moscow for security assurance. Given that this was exactly the kind of overdependence on one benefactor that Indian policymakers since the late 1960s had been trying to avoid, it is likely that this played a role in affecting the decision to go ahead on this front. As an American intelligence assessment at the time noted, the need to "hedge" against the questionable reliability and "durability" of the Soviet guarantee and to avoid overdependence on Moscow were key factors favoring such a decision.[299]

The Plot for a Farce by Molière

Concern about overdependence on Moscow also resulted in India welcoming the visit of former US treasury secretary John Connally in July 1972. Nixon had decided to send Connally as a signal, which the NSC had recommended, to start the repair job on the India relationship. Nixon wanted his envoy to make sure, however, that he did not give the impression that he was on an apology tour.[300] Condemnatory Indian statements on Vietnam in the run-up to Connally's visit had tempered any hope that the visit would be a turning point. The White House instructed Connally to assert to his Indian interlocutors that their "gratuitous slaps at US policy" were detrimental to US-India relations.[301]

During the discussions with Connally, Swaran Singh again welcomed Sino-US rapprochement, but indicated Indian anxiety that it "upset stabilizing forces in [the] Indian context." He implied that Pakistan was more intransigent because of Chinese and US support.[302] Gandhi, on her part, noted that the US needed to take the initiative to improve relations.[303] Nonetheless, at a press conference she herself took a step, calling for better US-Indian relations.[304]